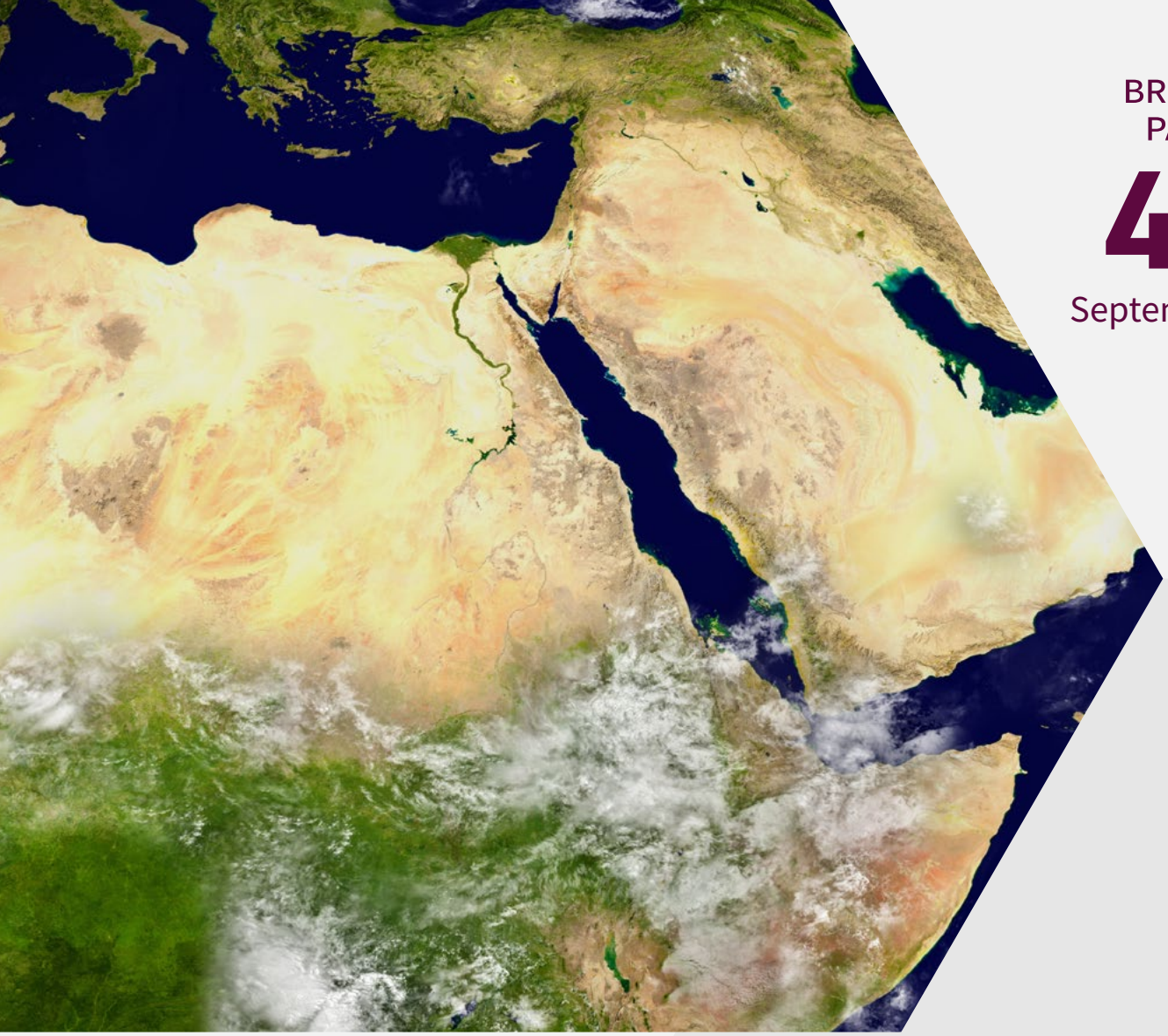


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The war in Sudan in the era of a multipolar world

Mismanaged rather than forgotten

Katariina Mustasilta

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Summary

- The war in Sudan is not a "forgotten war". Rather, it is a highly internationalised geopolitical battleground, reflecting old peacebuilding failures and key implications of the shifting international order for conflict dynamics.
- Nor is it a proxy war, as the involvement of external actors is opportunistic and issue-based, with state powers supporting different sides while maintaining cooperative ties elsewhere.
- Peace efforts in Sudan are fragmented and heavily influenced by geopolitical agendas, sidelining civilian agency and undermining multilateral frameworks for peace.
- For the EU, Sudan presents a challenge in reconciling its values-based approach with its pursuit of pragmatic foreign policy. From a long-term strategic perspective, it is imperative to support Sudanese-led peace efforts beyond transactional deals.

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Introduction

Well into its third year, the war in Sudan shows few signs of abating. The armed power struggle between the Sudanese Armed Forces (SAF) and their loose coalition of allies on one side, and the Rapid Support Forces (RSF) and their network of affiliated groups on the other, continues to drive a catastrophic humanitarian crisis and erode the democratic momentum generated by the nonviolent revolution of 2018–2019. The main parties remain entrenched in their positions, consolidating territorial lines of control and declaring rival governments. Analysts warn that the country faces the threat of partition.[1]

Since the start of the war, there have been several attempts at negotiations facilitated by multiple international and regional actors, the latest led by the United States in early autumn 2025.[2] However, none of these dispersed initiatives have succeeded in halting or significantly de-escalating the conflict.[3] The faltering conflict management attempts and the horrifying level of destruction have earned the war the nickname of *the forgotten war*, a reference to the inadequate attention that the conflict receives from major global powers.[4] Overshadowed by the wars in Ukraine and the Middle East, Sudan has certainly received scant attention in foreign and security policy discussions in Europe, for example.

Although the forgotten war narrative stems from understandable frustration, it is not particularly well suited to the crisis in Sudan and, at worst, may undermine efforts to address its enablers. As noted by numerous reports and analyses, rather than being forgotten, the conflict is closely monitored and subjected to direct interference from an array of neighbouring, regional, and international actors.[5] For many of these actors, the political, economic, and security dynamics in Sudan present valuable opportunities to advance their core interests and strengthen their regional and international influence. The apparent inattention of Western powers and liberal peacebuilding actors, including the European Union (EU), ultimately reflects their shifting geoeconomic and geostrategic interests as well as the changing power dynamics of the international system.

This Briefing Paper analyses the war in Sudan in the context of the shifting international order and its implications for conflict dynamics and their management. From this perspective, the war emerges as a key battleground in the intensifying geopolitical competition in a world characterised by multiple poles or nodes of regional and international power.

1 Khalafallah, Hamid (2025) "The Civilian Façade in Sudan's War: Rival Governments and the Battle for Legitimacy". The Tahrir Institute, 6 August. https://timep.org/2025/08/06/the-civilian-facade-in-sudans-war-rival-governments-and-the-battle-for-legitimacy/; Horner, Jonas (2025a) "Split decision: Why Sudan is on the brink of partition – again". Policy Brief, 27 February, European Council on Foreign Relations. https://ecfr.eu/publication/split-decision-why-sudan-is-on-the-brink-of-partition-again/.

2 After a cancelled meeting of the same group, the Sudan Quad, i.e. the US, Egypt, Saudi Arabia, and the UAE, announced a shared roadmap for ending the war, on 12 September. See U.S. Department of State (2025) Joint Statement on Restoring Peace and Security in Sudan. https://www.state.gov/releases/office-of-the-spokesperson/2025/09/joint-statement-on-restoring-peace-and-security-in-sudan/.

3 Khalafallah, Hamid (2024) "Breaking the cycle: Can Geneva Succeed Where Jeddah Failed in Sudan?" The Tahrir Institute, 14 August. https://timep.org/2024/08/14/breaking-the-cycle-can-geneva-succeed-where-jeddah-failed-in-sudan/.

4 See Booty, Natasha and Farouk Chothia (2025) Sudan war: a simple guide what is happening, *BBC News*, 4 July. https://www.bbc.com/news/articles/cjel2nn22z9o.

5 For an overview, see International Crisis Group (2025) "Sudan's Calamitous War: Finding a Path toward Peace". *Briefing N 204*. https://www.crisisgroup.org/africa/horn-africa/sudan/b204-sudans-calamitous-war-finding-path-toward-peace.

The paper highlights three prominent features of conflicts amid the shifting international order. First, while the internationalisation of armed conflicts is not a new phenomenon in Sudan or elsewhere, it is intensifying as the unipolar order gives way to a multipolar one with more assertive powers. Second, rather than taking the form of proxy wars, these conflicts increasingly involve external actors entangled in the primary conflict and its political economy, yet less locked into fixed adversarial positions with each other. This both complicates and leaves room for conflict management.

Third, conflict management efforts are ever more centred on the positions, (geo)economic and (geo)strategic interests, and relative strength of the armed actors and their backers. This risks further marginalising local civilian agencies and leaving the causes of conflict unaddressed. Without multilateral efforts to address the geopolitical drivers and support Sudanese civic actors, conflict management will, at best, produce deals that repeat past mistakes of forging elite-level, unsustainable pacts.

War embedded in political and conflict legacies

The current war in Sudan escalated in April 2023, when the power struggle between General Abdel Fattah al-Burhan and General Mohamed Hamdan "Hemedti" Dagalo erupted over the issue of integrating Hemedti's RSF into the national army (SAF). The two generals had risen to power in spring 2019 after ousting their former patron, authoritarian leader Omar al-Bashir, following a massive pro-democracy uprising. Having initially agreed to a civil-military-led democratisation process, the two generals launched a coup d'état in October 2021, only to find themselves increasingly at odds with one another over future power distribution. Notably, the military heads had significant foreign support in their rise to power, particularly from Saudi Arabia and the United Arab Emirates (UAE), which saw the events as an opportunity to advance their own regional and strategic interests.[6]

The roots of the war lie in the historical legacies of oppressive military rule, politically manipulated regional and ethnic tensions, and violent conflict in Sudan.[7] Since independence, state power in Sudan has most often been seized through military coups, with security, political, and economic spheres of power increasingly concentrated in the hands of a few. This was the case under the al-Bashir regime (1989–2019), which presided over the Second Sudanese Civil War and the subsequent partition of the country, a genocide against non-Arab groups in Darfur, and the consolidation of wealthy, powerful paramilitary leaders, such as General Hemedti. The growth of a broad-based, unarmed pro-democracy movement from 2018 to 2019 provided distinctive momentum to sow the seeds for more pluralistic governance in Sudan.[8] However, to have had any chance of succeeding, the transition towards democratic rule would have required the military elites to give up substantial power and face accountability for their abuses of power. Sudanese experts and activists repeatedly warned the international community that this would not happen without significant and concerted pressure on the generals.[9]

The war was initially concentrated in Khartoum, but quickly spread to other regions in Sudan. The RSF and its allies have gradually consolidated control in Darfur and West Kordofan, although the besieged city of El Fasher remains under SAF control. Since spring 2025, the SAF has controlled the north and east of the country, including Khartoum. In July 2025, the RSF declared a rival government to the SAF-led one in Port Sudan and presented a transition plan for the country, heightening concerns about its fragmentation.

The humanitarian toll of the war has been catastrophic. Over 150,000 people have died, and over 12 million people have been forced to leave their homes, creating the world's worst displacement crisis. Famine has been declared in multiple areas

6 Horner 2025a; Perteghella, Annalisa (2020) "A Pax Arabica for Sudan?". ISPI. https://www.ispionline.it/en/publication/pax-arabica-sudan-26189.

7 Flint, Julie and Alex de Waal (2007) *Darfur: A New History of a Long War* (revised and updated). London: Zed Books.

8 Mustasilta, Katariina (2019) "Three Scenarios for Sudan: From nonviolent revolution to democratic reform?". *EUISS Conflict Series Brief,* 10. European Union Institute for Security Studies (EUISS).

9 Luck, Taylor (2023) "Sudanese to world: Violence in Khartoum shows strongmen can't be trusted". The Christian Science Monitor, 18 April. https://www.csmonitor.com/World/Africa/2023/0418/Sudanese-to-world-Violence-in-Khartoum-shows-strongmen-can-t-be-trusted.

in Darfur, and approximately half of the population (25 million people) face acute hunger. Both parties stand accused of war crimes against the civilian population, including the use of rape as a weapon of war. The RSF and allied militias, in particular, face accusations of genocidal violence in Darfur.[10]

Not a proxy war but a reflection of the fragmented multipolar world

Rather than mobilising large-scale popular support among the Sudanese people, the continued armed struggle is enabled by a plethora of internal and external affiliates and supporters with diverse, and at times competing, economic, political, and security interests. Internally, uneasy coalitions of armed and political actors have formed behind the two key parties: the SAF is backed by members of the former al-Bashir government and Islamist groups, as well as some of the armed groups that formerly rebelled against the state. The RSF, in turn, has allied with rival political elites and armed militias, and has recently established the Tasis alliance with the prominent armed group, the Sudan People's Liberation Movement-North (SPLM-N). The networked nature of the warring parties further complicates negotiations, accelerates localised violence against civilians, and risks spoiling any agreements that are reached. The co-optation of civilian groups has fragmented and weakened the pro-democracy forces, yet grassroots groups such as the Emergency Response Rooms (ERRs) continue to present an alternative to the military-led factions.[11]

Entangled in these domestic networks, Sudan's war is fuelled by the interference of multiple external actors and the transboundary and international flow of goods, arms, and financial and political support. The UAE is widely considered the key external enabler of the RSF's armed struggle, including through the provision of arms, which it denies. The SAF's chief supporters include Egypt, Iran, and Saudi Arabia. Neighbouring countries and other international actors – from Chad, Libya, Kenya, and Ethiopia to Russia, Turkey, and Qatar – have also allegedly sided with, and at times shifted support to, different sides in the conflict. Figure 1 presents a simplified mapping of the key external states involved.

As Figure 1 shows, Sudan is a prime example of a highly internationalised civil war in that the primary conflict parties receive support, including weaponry, from foreign state actors. While foreign interference in civil conflicts is not a new phenomenon, the scope and nature of internationalisation are shifting compared with the Cold War's bipolarity and the post-Cold War unipolar moment of liberal order. In 2000, only four out of 40 internal conflicts were internationalised, whereas in 2024, they were 19 out of 61, in addition to an increased number of inter-state armed conflicts. [12] As Sudan illustrates, more state powers are involved than before, and a defining feature is the relatively even-handed interference of regional and aspiring great powers, sometimes alongside and sometimes replacing global power rivalry. Far from being a forgotten war, Sudan is a crowded battlefield of the shifting world order.

"Far from being a forgotten war, Sudan is a crowded battlefield of the shifting world order."

External interference in Sudan is driven by a series of factors, including its strategic location between the Red Sea and the Sahel, as well as its position as a bridge between Sub-Saharan Africa and the Arab world. Other drivers include its rich natural resources, particularly gold, as well as security and political rationales, such as opposition to or promotion of political Islam.[13] These factors are not new,

10 See Booty, Natasha and Farouk Chothia (2025) "Sudan war: a simple guide to what is happening", *BBC News*, 4 July. https://www.bbc.com/news/articles/cjel2nn22z9o; Mishra, Vibhu (2025) "Sudan faces unprecedented hunger and displacement as war enters third year". UN News. https://news.un.org/en/story/2025/04/1162096.

11 See Khalafallah, Hamid (2025) "Sudan's Counterrevolutionary War: The Systematic Targeting of Pro-Democracy Activists". The Tahrir Institute, 15 April. https://timep.org/2025/04/15/sudans-counterrevolutionary-war-the-systematic-targeting-of-pro-democracy-activists/.

12 Davies, Shawn, Therese Pettersson, Margareta Sollenberg and Magnus Öberg (2025) "Organized violence 1989–2024, and the challenges of identifying civilian victims". *Journal of Peace Research*, 62(4); Hellmüller, Sara and Fanny Badache (2025) "Children of their time: The impact of world politics on United Nations peace operations". *Contemporary Security Policy* 46 (2): 177–196. https://doi.org/10.1080/13523260.2025.2470590; Mustasilta, Katariina (2021) "The future of conflict prevention – Preparing for a hotter, increasingly digital and fragmented 2030", *Chaillot Paper,* 167. European Union Institute of Security Studies (EUISS).

13 Horner 2025a.

External interference in the war in Sudan

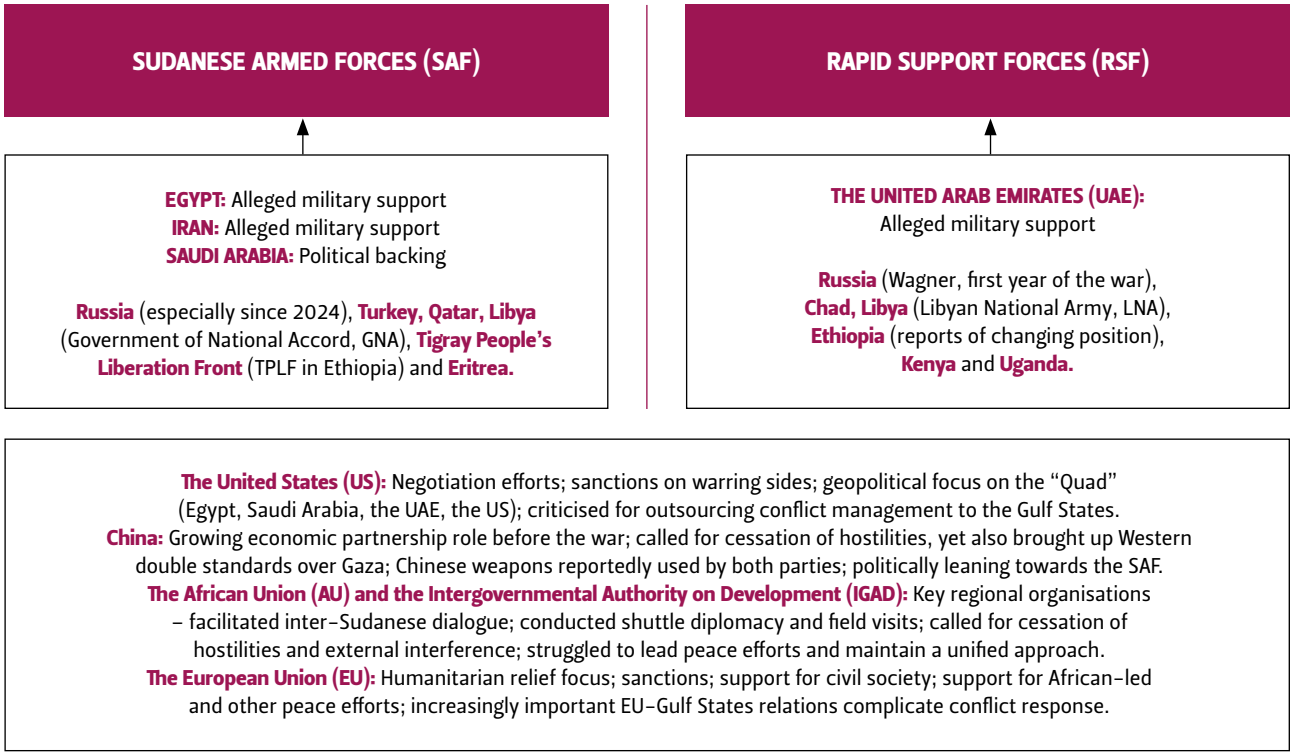


Figure 1. External interference in the war in Sudan. The figure lists the alleged external state supporters of the two main parties, organised from key backers to other actors reportedly aligning with either side. The list is not exhaustive and simplifies the complex networks among these actors. The third section outlines the role of key global powers and regional organisations.
Source: The figure builds on several research and news reports on international dynamics in the Sudan war; see, for example, Horner (2025a) and ICG (2025).

and existing ties, such as those between Egypt and the SAF leadership, continue to shape the direction of external support. Nevertheless, the fragmenting international system makes these aspects ever more attractive – or vulnerable – to foreign interference in conflicts: great powers, aspiring great powers, and regional powers strive to secure strategic advantages and regional influence in an environment characterised by declining trust in established international norms and institutions. Political upheavals create opportunities to expand influence, and the involvement of external actors becomes a vicious cycle in which a state's deeper involvement in a conflict fuels the involvement of others.

However, this does not make the conflict in Sudan a proxy war. It is primarily a power struggle between Sudanese actors, rooted in the question of the nature of governance in the country. Moreover, the concept of a proxy war misrepresents the logic behind external actors' interference in many of today's armed conflicts. Such interference is often driven less by ideological battles or deep enmity between foreign powers on opposing sides, and is more complex and context-specific regarding the underlying international relations. Take the interference of the UAE and Egypt in Sudan, for example. The two countries support opposite sides in the war. Yet outside of the conflict, their relationship is more cooperative than conflicting, with the UAE being a strategically important partner for Egypt. This reflects a more general feature of today's international system: partnerships are opportunistic rather than deeply ideological and often issue- and sector-based, and therefore amenable. While this

makes multilateralism difficult and agreed settlements more unstable, it can also create opportunities for negotiation, both at the general geopolitical level and regarding specific issues.

Implications for conflict management attempts

As Sudan's conflict history testifies, the shortcomings and weak implementation of past peace deals have contributed to the current protracted conflicts. There is little point in romanticising the past US-led order during which liberal values and norms, such as the promotion of free-market democracy, human rights, and inclusion, may have been more dominant but were often poorly implemented in peace-making practice. Rather, the point here is to underline some of the implications of the shifting international order for conflict management dynamics. In this regard, the shift towards a multipolar order shapes peace efforts in Sudan, and more broadly, in two primary ways: by increasing the number of actors – "the chefs in the kitchen" – that have the influence and incentives to initiate conflict management efforts, and by intensifying the contestation of established norms and institutions.

There have been several rounds of negotiation efforts regarding the war in Sudan, facilitated by various international and regional powers: for example, by Saudi Arabia and the US in Jeddah in May 2023; by Arab intelligence services in Manama in early 2024; by the US, Saudi Arabia, and Switzerland in Geneva in August 2024; by Turkey in early 2025; and by the US in July 2025. These talks have brought together different sets of primary conflict parties and external states, but have shown little coordination and connection between initiatives. Regional and neighbouring countries have also hosted talks between and among the diverse Sudanese coalitions, while the EU and the UK have hosted conferences on the humanitarian situation and facilitated talks among Sudanese civil society actors.

A notable feature of conflict management efforts is the dual role played by regional actors. For example, both Qatar and Saudi Arabia have presented themselves as neutral peacemakers while reportedly supporting the SAF, whereas Egypt – the SAF's key supporter – is considered essential in facilitating relations between the UAE and the SAF. Biased third parties with leverage over certain warring actors taking on mediation roles is nothing new. Such involvement can be effective in pressuring their favoured side to commit. Yet achieving credible commitments becomes difficult when multiple conflict management initiatives overlap and regional powers act as peacemakers while continuing to support parties to the conflict.

This is particularly the case when – as in Sudan – there is no coordinated pressure on the external powers themselves. This stems in part from intensifying great-power competition and norms contestation within the UN Security Council, which has prevented a strong global multilateral response to the war.[14] It also stems from the intertwined interests of global and increasingly assertive regional powers. For the US, and likewise for the EU as discussed below, economic and security relations with the Gulf States have become increasingly important in today's more competitive world. Both actors now have less leverage over these states and seemingly less willingness to exercise that leverage.

"Negotiation efforts have largely focused on geopolitical issues, without much consideration for the deep and justified grievances and mistrust that Sudanese civil society has towards the military elites."

Meanwhile, the region's key multilateral actors, particularly the African Union (AU) and the Intergovernmental Authority on Development (IGAD), have struggled to assume leadership and provide credible, acceptable frameworks for coordinating conflict management efforts. The existing rules and institutions, such as the arms embargo on Darfur, as well as peacebuilding norms, such as inclusivity in peace processes, have been grossly neglected. Consequently, negotiation efforts have

14 Thus far, the Security Council has called for an end to the siege of El Fasher and has extended the Sudan sanctions regime, including targeted sanctions and an arms embargo (on Darfur). See Security Council Report (2025) September 2025 Monthly Forecast for Sudan. https://www.securitycouncilreport.org/monthly-forecast/2025-09/sudan-37.php.

largely focused on geopolitical issues, namely the interests of external backers and key Sudanese military leaders, without much consideration for the deep and justified grievances and mistrust that Sudanese civil society has towards the military elites. President Trump's attempt to bring together the Sudan Quad – the US, Saudi Arabia, the UAE, and Egypt – is apparently modelled on his peace agreement between Rwanda and the Democratic Republic of Congo, with natural resource control and power- sharing deals in exchange for peace.[15] Again, such transactional deals are not new to the field of peace-making. Yet there was a time in the post-Cold war period when the dominance of liberal values and norms helped in putting pressure on both national and international actors to strive for inclusion and to address the root causes of conflicts in negotiations. Now, the balance is shifting (back) to the side of the armed actors and their backers.

The way forward: Carving out space to support Sudanese peace

In a system marked by growing power competition and declining multilateralism, ad hoc efforts and transactionalism seem to prevail and characterise conflict responses. The most realistic scenario for a brokered deal may well be a Trumpian-style settlement centred on control over and benefits from Sudan's key strategic (natural) resources, with little regard for what happens next or beyond the geopolitical dynamics. This will not bring about sustainable peace, however; at best it may buy time, and at worst it risks derailing Sudanese efforts to create the conditions for peace and legitimate governance.

The resulting dynamics of conflict management are particularly challenging for Sudanese grassroots democracy and human rights activists and groups. They are also difficult for multilateral organisations, such as the AU, and for traditional liberal actors, particularly the EU, whose roles as conflict responders are built on commitments to multilateralism, facilitative and coordinating (rather than highly manipulative) mediation, and an inclusive approach to peace processes. To gain any leverage over the armed parties or their external backers, these actors would also require unity among their members, which is difficult to attain in the current international climate.

The situation in Sudan is particularly challenging for the EU. On the one hand, it has tried to maintain the moral high ground on the war by stepping up humanitarian support for the Sudanese, imposing sanctions based on UN SC mandates, and publicly supporting the AU and other regional efforts. On the other hand, the EU has paid relatively little attention to Sudan in its geopolitical engagement with the Gulf States, for example, with whom it simultaneously seeks to deepen economic relations through bilateral and multilateral frameworks.[16] This tension between its conflict-response identity and its geopolitical agency ultimately risks weakening its credibility as an actor on all fronts.

Even if united, the EU and its member states could not, on their own, pressure the key external actors to stop fuelling the war. Yet, given its evolving relations with the Gulf States and its networks with Sudanese civil society actors, the EU could be well placed to help connect the different tracks of conflict management and, in particular, to convince regional powers of the futility of continuing to unequivocally support Sudan's military actors. This does not need to be done from a position of moral authority. Rather, the EU should build its diplomatic engagements around the long-term strategic interests and political reputation of all key external actors.

In concrete terms, the EU and its member states could also step up support for Sudanese pro-democracy groups and civic actors. Local civic actors, such as the ERRs, have become increasingly important grassroots governance actors during the war, and are consequently trusted and regarded as legitimate by many Sudanese.[17] More broadly, they represent a much-needed localised model for aid delivery, from which valuable lessons can be drawn in the current context of weakening international

15 See Mohammed, Abdul and Alex de Waal (2025) "Only the Sudanese Can Save Sudan – Even if Trump Stops the War". World Peace Foundation, 16 July. https://worldpeacefoundation.org/blog/only-the-sudanese-can-save-sudan-even-if-trump-stops-the-war/.

16 Sidło, Katarzyna (2025) "Calibrated engagement: Evolving relations between the EU and the Gulf Region". *EUISS Brief* 18, EUISS. https://www.iss.europa.eu/sites/default/files/2025-07/Brief_2024_18_GCC_3.pdf.

17 Khaid, Kholood (2024) "Local aid groups are keeping Sudan alive". *The World Today,* Chatham House. https://www.chathamhouse.org/publications/the-world-today/2024-12/local-aid-groups-are-keeping-sudan-alive; Horner, Jonas (2025b) "The falcons and the secretary bird: Arab Gulf states in Sudan's war". *Policy Brief*, 30 July, ECFR. https://ecfr.eu/publication/the-falcons-and-the-secretary-bird-arab-gulf-states-in-sudans-war/.

cooperation regimes. The abolition of USAID, the US foreign aid agency, has undermined their ability to work, and increased EU support would be well in line with both its values and its pragmatic interests.

In a world of transactional deals and realpolitik, calls for inclusive processes, civilian empowerment, and efforts to address the root causes of conflict may seem old-fashioned. Yet in Sudan, as elsewhere, whether these factors are addressed or neglected will determine what happens after agreements are signed. Support for pro-democratic and local human rights groups should not be seen as taking the moral high ground, but rather as a strategic priority in the long-term perspective – both for the stability of Sudan and for international security. This is particularly true from the perspective of international actors such as the EU, for whom global democratic backsliding and the rising militarisation of international politics present serious geopolitical and security challenges.

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